

ADVANCED MELODIC PLAYING

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #115

One of the best ways to think about developing as an improviser is to understand that "those who know the most melodies are the best improvisors." Now, this doesn't just mean jazz songs. This is ANY good melody. Jazz songs, folks songs, traditional songs, TV themes. Anything. See if you can pick out some melodies on your instrument. You may be surprised at how difficult this is for many of us, even with songs we've heard for decades.

#1 - Twinkle, Twinkle



#2 - God Save The Queen



#3 - Happy Birthday



#4 - St. Thomas



Now for a more advanced approach. We want to get comfortable improvising "Pure Melody." Not in a given key or scale, or with a particular groove or tempo. Simply one note moving to another, on their own terms. Pure Melody. It's HARD to do, but crucile to learn. This is work that is definitely best done with a mentor and with regular feedback. There are a lot of ways to do it less efficiently, or even incorrectly.

Some Ideas and Thoughts and Starting Points -

- Don't worry about making your melody sound like "jazz." We aren't playing jazz right now.
- Don't stay in a given key or scale. If you notice you are (and you will), just play a "wrong note" to get you out of the key.
- Don't rely on direct repetition, or riffs or little "hooks." Pure evolving melody.
- Don't stay in time, or with a groove (for now). Let it flow. Pure Melody.
- Think of the first note you play as the first note of a five minute long solo concerto.
- Try to hear "what comes next." Don't just reflexively play things you know. Listen for "what comes next" in your melody.
- What is your emotion RIGHT NOW? Bored, anxious, confused, pissed off at Jeff? THAT is exactly what your melody should sound like. Bored, or anxious, or pissed off. Link your melody to emotion, not intellect.